

Delores Swallows



In the Shadow of
The Riot

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Punks on Tour

by Delores Swallows

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In the Shadow of The Riot

It's 1979 and Britain's youth are still clinging on to the punk rock era.

Jag's band, Frenzy, has been invited to join two other bands as support acts for The Riot as they tour the Midlands.

One of the other support acts is an all-girl punk band from Liverpool, and their bass player's caught Jag's eye.

Is it all sex, drugs and Rock'n'Roll?

No, but two out of three ain't bad...

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In the Shadow of The Riot

Ψ



Chapter One

Jag stood to the left of the drums and played the final few bars of the song on his battered Telecaster. He watched their lead singer strutting along the edge of the stage; Jag knew Wood would be glaring at the pale, vacant faces of the people moshing on the floor in front of him. The drums and bass built to a crescendo, and even though the crowd seemed completely oblivious to the drummer not keeping the timing constant, Jag was still annoyed with him. He cart-wheeled his arm Townshend-style for each of the final three strikes of the A chord.

The lights went out, the crowd roared, and Wood gave his usual end-of-gig, “thank you, and fuck off.” With his cockney accent it sounded more like *Fankoo and fack orf*.

There were a few laughs and jeers from the crowd as the band left the stage and the audience headed towards the bar. Strobe lights lit the floor as the DJ took over from the live music. The Sex Pistols’ *No Feelings* belted out of the speakers, the volume so high the bass vibrated through the floor. It could be felt in the tiny office near the rear entrance where the band got changed.

Wood was looking down in disgust at the mess on his black drain-pipe jeans and ripped white t-shirt. “I swear, if I can get close enough to any of those cunts who gob on me, I’ll kick their fucking teeth down their throat.”

Muzza paused from drinking a can of cider. “Maybe you should learn to play the drums. Twats can’t gob that far.”

Biff looked up from his chair in the corner. “Piss off. Some people think the best thing about this band’s their drummer.”

Muzza laughed. “The only person who thinks that’s your mum. She told me when I was shagging her the other night.”

Biff responded by throwing a plastic glass full of beer in Muzza’s direction, with most of the contents splattering Wood’s legs.

“Cunt!”

“Might help getting the phlegm off the jeans,” Jag pointed out.

Wood muttered more profanities as he made his way towards the clean gear slung over the back of his chair and started to undress.

Each band member changed from sweat-drenched clothes into a dry set which looked just like the ones removed. They all had their own style. Wood always wore tight black jeans, winkle-picker boots and a ripped white t-shirt; Biff chose ripped blue denim jeans with a black t-shirt, while Muzza was always in black leather trousers and a blue denim jacket with both sleeves cut off, showing off his muscles and tattoos. Jag favoured faded blue jeans with one of a large selection of coloured t-shirts that he'd splashed with bleach. He was privately proud of the fact several people in their audience had copied his style and made their own versions of the shirts.

Once changed, they made way through the crowd towards the bar. Whenever they performed here they were paid £30 cash plus free drinks. They always drank as much as they could to get the most from the deal. There were familiar faces in the club, many of their fans following the band to each venue they played. Some were friends they'd known since school, others were people they'd met in punk clubs. Jag and Muzza had started the group a couple of years earlier, Biff joining a few months later when the original drummer moved to London to join one of Malcolm McLaren's lesser-known acts. It was Biff who'd come up with their current name of 'Frenzy'. Wood was their third lead vocalist. The first had left to go to university, the second was told to leave and go to rehab. Although Wood had his faults, the rest of the band knew he wouldn't turn up to gigs so high he couldn't even talk, let alone sing. He'd caught the train up to Manchester to audition having read the advert in Melody Maker, and had now been with the band for nearly twelve months. Jag felt this was their strongest line-up to date, and knew if they were going to make it, it would have to be soon.

Sid Vicious had died almost six months earlier and Margaret Thatcher — clearly not held back by mass youth unpopularity — had become Prime Minister a few months after that. Jag felt the punk movement had already lost some of its momentum. He knew this was his big chance to break away from his boring job in the warehouse. He'd spent endless hours locked in his bedroom, writing songs and improving his guitar technique, and couldn't bear the thought of not seeing any rewards for all of his dedication.

As they drank and chilled by the bar, a young blond girl wearing a mini skirt and ripped fishnet tights approached Muzza. She had thick black eye-liner, green eye-shadow and black lipstick. Muzza slid his thick arm around her tiny waist and pulled her close, kissing her on the ear.

“Lads, this is Betty.”

The rest of the band either nodded or raised a glass in greeting.

Wood took a lingering look at her legs, and then smiled at Muzza. “I think she reminds me a bit of Zoe.”

“Fuck off and find your own bird.” Muzza pulled Betty closer to him and led her into the heaving mass of people thrashing around to The Clash’s *White Riot*.

Mickey, one of their fans, almost tripped up getting out of Muzza’s way and looked questioningly at Biff. “What was that all about?”

“Just Wood trying to get his end away.”

Mickey looked blank. “What?”

Biff went into it. “A few months ago we played a festival in Leeds. Muzza tapped off with some bird called Zoe, but she ended up shagging all of us that night.”

Mickey’s eyes lit up. “What, a gangbang?”

“Naw, yer sick cunt – one at a time.” Biff rolled his eyes. “We were all camping there, and after she’d had Muzza, he fell asleep. She came to look for the rest of the band. We didn’t know ‘til next morning she’d had us all.”

Mickey was shaking his head. “Fucking dirty bitch. What was she like?”

“Filthy. She made me do her doggy-style while I played a four-four beat on her arse.”

Somebody else chipped in. “Maybe she was Catholic and used the rhythm method.”

As groans sounded from the others, Jag said, “I bet you speeded up the timing towards the end of that, as well.”

Biff’s eyes narrowed as he picked upon Jag’s little dig. “Alright, fuck off.”

Wood slid his gaze between guitarist and drummer, but shrugged off their cryptic exchange. “She made you fuck her doggy-style so she didn’t have to smell your breath.”

“Cheeky cunt.” Then Biff added, for Mickey’s benefit, “Jag liked her so much he wrote a song about her.”

“Yeah?” Mickey looked towards Jag. “Which one?”

“Feel Alright.”

Mickey’s eyes closed slightly as he hummed the tune, like he was mentally recalling the lyrics. “So this Zoe is Ellen O’Ride?”

Jag nodded. “Her real name’s Ellen O’Rourke. Zoe’s just her nickname.”

“How d’you know that?” Wood looked surprised.

Jag shrugged. “I talked to her.”

“Before or after you fucked her?”

“Both. She told me she was eighteen and had never shagged the same guy twice.”

Wood shook his head. “I had her twice.”

Jag laughed. “I expect a lot of the men she’s been with did – she seems insatiable. But she never sees any of them again, like on a second date. She reckons she only gets turned on by screwing men she’s never had before.”

Mickey was even more impressed now. “Fucking Hell, hot little slut. Wish I’d gone to Leeds.”

Biff punched him on the arm. “She might be a fucking nymph, but she’s not blind. She wouldn’t touch an ugly twat like you.”

Jag leaned towards Mickey but spoke loud enough for everyone to hear. “She told me she makes the ugly ones shag her from behind.”

It took a few seconds before Biff realised what Jag had meant. “Oi! Fuck off!”

* * * *

The evening carried on in the usual vein for the next hour or so. The band played from ten until eleven and the bar closed at midnight. The police were actively looking for reasons to shut the place down, so the owners always made sure they abided by the set licensing laws. Biff left with a dark-haired girl Jag hadn’t seen before, and Wood had agreed to share a taxi with two girls he’d spent the last half-hour chatting up.

Jag shared a small terraced house with Muzza, and he made the short walk home alone. He had to be at work at eight in the morning, so he’d not joined in with the woman-chasing like the others. As he

approached the door, he hoped for a more pleasant home-coming than the last time they'd played locally. He still had nightmares about opening the front door to the sight of Muzza's hairy arse bouncing up and down on the stairs, a dark-haired woman in red fishnets lying beneath him shouting 'Fuck me, Tiger!' over and over.

As it turned out, Jag was the first back to the house and was already in his bedroom when he heard Muzza and Betty arrive shortly afterwards. By the time the amorous couple had made it up to Muzza's bedroom, Jag was in bed with *Who's Next* on his cassette deck and his headphones turned up high. *Baba O'Reilly* filled his head, but not even Keith Moon's drumming could disguise the vibrations in the floor as Muzza's bed banged against his bedroom wall again and again.

* * * *

On the following night, Frenzy was lined up to play in Stockport at a club called Bingo. Muzza's brother owned a battered old Ford Transit and regularly hauled their gear around. He'd dropped them off just after seven and promised to return around midnight, hoping to catch the end of their set before taking them all home again.

As they carried their instruments and amps through the stage door, Muzza said, "There's something not right with our Graham. He spends every Friday night and most of his pay-pocket watching greyhounds chase a fake fuckin' rabbit round a track."

"Unlike his younger brother," Biff pointed out, "who spends most of his time chasing all sorts of dogs and shagging any of 'em he can catch."

With the gear set up, Biff, Muzza and Jag ran through the first couple of verses of *C'Mon Everybody*, a rock'n'roll classic regularly covered by the Pistols. When they'd finished, Wood turned on his mic and asked if any of the bar-staff would care to help him into his stage clothes later. The three young men paused in setting up the liquor optics to shout a few obscenities, and that was it: sound-check complete. The band made their way out of the club in search of a pub for a few beers to get them ready for the first set, which was due to start at ten.

The club was busy when they got back and by the time they'd changed and got on stage, the entire dance floor was crammed with punk-clad figures. Biff hit four rim-taps to count the rest of the band in, and as the drums, guitar and bass belted out of the amps, the entire audience began to

pogo to the beat. After the one-minute intro, Wood walked to the front of the stage and sang the first lines of *Reckless Driver*, their usual opening song.

*‘Maybe I’m a reckless driver, but I get what I want
Why should I spend my life at the back when I would rather live at
the front?’*

They followed up that with five more original songs and the crowd was wild. A few people moshed so violently some tables got knocked over and drinks spilt. A minor skirmish broke out which the bouncers had to break up. The band finished their first set with a punked-up version of the Beatles’ *Come Together*, and then went in search of beer and women. There was a thirty-minute break between the first and second set, during which time Wood managed to drink four pints of lager and start two fights by propositioning girls with boyfriends. This was becoming a regular occurrence; Jag and Muzza had both recently pointed out to Wood that life would be easier if he just tried to chat up the single women. Wood just laughed and grabbed his own crotch, saying ‘Every woman wants some of the Wood-wood.’

* * * *

Jag was pleased with the second set they played, and the crowd seemed more than happy, shouting and stamping their feet at the end until they agreed to play another song. They didn’t usually bother with an encore.

When they all got back into the cellar they were using as a dressing room, the club’s owner was there with another man. He was somewhere in his late twenties in a grey suit with dress shirt, but no tie. The club owner introduced the stranger as Simon Beeston.

The band all nodded, but none of them offered a hand in greeting.

“I’ve been hearing about Frenzy for a few weeks now,” he said in a posh accent.

Jag took an instant dislike to him, and noticed a couple of the others felt the same — all folded arms and blank stares.

The guy smiled warmly, clearly trying to thaw the cold front surrounding him. ‘So when Davy told me he’d booked you for his club, I thought I should come and see you in the flesh.’

Muzza smiled and dropped his leather trousers. "Here you go then."

The guy tried to laugh it off. "No, seriously, I wanted to see you play live, and I'm very glad I did." He looked at every member of the band, one after the other. "I think you boys have really got something."

Biff was the first to respond. "Well if we have, we probably all caught it from Zoe."

Simon was momentarily speechless while the rest of the band chuckled. Jag didn't know which he found the funnier, Biff's joke or the posh guy's discomfort.

Simon steered things back to his prepared speech. "I'd like the opportunity to manage you, if you're interested in really getting into the music business."

The room was suddenly quiet, and the band members looked at each other.

"Do you have a manager at the moment?" Simon asked.

They shook their heads. Jag noticed with pride how the band reacted to an outsider. He realised they were acting as a single unit, and it felt good to be part of it.

"Well, if you're interested in taking yourselves any further, I think it would be a logical step." Simon was looking mainly at Wood, evidently assuming that the lead singer he would also be the spokesman.

Muzza spoke for the band. "What's in it for us?"

Simon smiled, as if he already knew this would be the first question. "I'll arrange for you to perform at a few better venues." With that, he smiled at Davy. "Not that there's anything wrong with his club, but I'd like to see you playing in front of bigger audiences. I also have some contacts in London, so I'd like to get you signed to a record company."

Wood asked the obvious second question. "And what's in it for you?"

"Well, we can treat the first month as a trial, and I'll only get my expenses paid. But if you're happy with the direction we're going in, then I would expect twenty five percent."

Jag spoke up first. "That's too much."

Wood was nodding his agreement. "There's no way I'm standing up there and getting covered in gob for two hours while you sit at the bar and earn more than me."

Simon had probably been expecting this and put in a high figure he'd be happy to reduce. "I could go as low as twenty. But don't forget, if I get you performing at bigger gigs, you'll all be earning a lot more than you do at the moment. Eighty percent of that figure will be far more than the full one hundred percent you're taking now."

There was a temporary silence while this sunk in.

"And if I manage to convince my contacts they should give you a recording contract, then your earnings will increase exponentially."

Muzza looked thoughtful, thick dark eyebrows furrowing above his dark brown eyes. "You should only get a percentage of whatever you set up. We already have some regular bookings, so I don't see why you should get twenty percent of something you've had fuck all to do with arranging."

Simon narrowed his eyes slightly while he considered how best to play this. But Jag followed up with another point.

"And we sell cassettes of our songs after our gigs. Since we paid to get them recorded, I don't think you're entitled to twenty percent of that, either."

Simon saw the other band members were all nodding their heads, and he had to accept this – at least, for the time being. "Fair enough. I'll get some contracts drawn up, and you can come down to my office and sign them as soon as they're ready."

Wood smiled. "I suppose it's not worth signing them until the first trial month is up. That'll give us all time to see if we are *happy with the direction we're going*." He smirked, knowing his piss-take of Simon's accent had impressed the other lads.

Simon forced a smile, but there was no humour there. He held out four business cards, spreading them like a magician doing a trick. Each band member took a card, but only Jag bothered to read it. Blue gothic script announced *Simon Beeston, Beeston Holdings Ltd*, and a Manchester phone number which was presumably for his office.

"Well," Simon said as he made his way to the door. "Thank you for the show tonight, and I assure you we'll soon be taking steps up to a better future."

As soon as he'd left the room, Jag, Muzza, Biff and Wood all looked at each other, half-smiling, half shocked.

"What a cunt." Biff was his usual astute self.

Jag held up the business card. "Simon Beeston Holdings."

Muzza snorted. "Simon Beastly, more like."

"Well he won't be fucking holding me," Biff said. "Fucker thinks he's Brian Einstein."

Jag looked at Muzza and shook his head, appalled at their drummer's ignorance.

"Yeah," Muzza said. "The man's a fucking genius."

"But it's all relative," Jag chuckled.

"Wha'?" Biff looked between them, perplexed.

Jag laughed and twisted Biff's nipple. "It was Brian fucking *Epstein*, yer dickhead. Einstein was a German physicist. Even you must have heard of *The Theory of Relativity*?"

Biff continued to look confused, now rubbing his sore nipple and looking hugely hard-done-by.

"Did you actually ever go to school?" Muzza asked him.

"Piss off. I was going to be a teach—" Biff was drowned out by their laughter.

"Like fuck! There's no way anyone would let you near a schoolgirl, you dirty little twat."

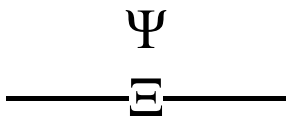
Biff grinned and grabbed his own crotch. "I could teach them a thing or two. Take all the fit ones into the stock room for some private French lessons."

The band changed and went out into the club, where one of the men who'd earlier had a go at Wood for chatting up his girlfriend was waiting with three of his friends. Muzza saw them first and walked over to try to defuse the situation. When he realised how agitated and drunk the offended man was, he didn't even bother trying to talk to him. Muzza head-butted him in the face and the guy dropped like a sack of potatoes, blood pouring from his broken nose. His three friends lost their nerve and backed off, dragging their half-conscious leader with them.

Muzza returned to the rest of the band and they all headed towards the bar.

"Another quiet night out with Frenzy," Biff announced.





Chapter Two

Over the next couple of weeks, very little seemed to have changed as far as band management and gigs were concerned. Frenzy played another of their regular spots at Stark, and a couple of other one-offs they'd booked a few months back.

After a fortnight, Simon turned up at Stark, looking smug. "Well boys, thanks to me you're going to be busy during the next few weeks. I've booked you on a short tour with three other bands."

Jag looked at Muzza and they both raised their eyebrows. "A tour?"

Simon nodded. "Yes. There will be eight performances over nine days."

"Where are we going?" Biff couldn't keep the smile from his face.

"All over the Midlands. You'll start in Stoke, then down to Birmingham, Wolverhampton, Coventry, and two nights in Leicester. There's one in Derby and you finish up in Nottingham."

Muzza smiled. "A bit like Robin Hood."

Jag was thinking about arranging time off work. Wood had rich parents and didn't seem to need to work at all. Muzza and Biff both had casual arrangements where they were paid when they turned up. Jag's, however, was a permanent job where he got a set number of holidays per year. "When does it start?"

Simon smiled again. "First gig is next Wednesday. The main band is 'The Riot', and the support acts are yourselves, 'Gash', and a not-very-pleasant sounding 'Fresh Scabs'.

Jag was impressed but tried not to show it. He'd heard of Gash, an all-girl punk band from Liverpool. He'd actually paid to see The Riot play the previous year. He was also aware that 'The Scabs' had recently split, and two members had formed a new band. He suspected this would probably be Fresh Scabs.

"What about getting around and sleeping?" Muzza was obviously worried he'd be dossing down in his brother's Transit van for over a week.

“There’s going to be a coach for transport, and I’ve booked you into lodging houses for each night.” Simon raised his finger, his face serious. “However, if there is *any* trouble or damage, it’ll be deducted from whatever you earn.”

Biff seemed impressed with Simon’s band-management so far. “And what will we be earning?”

“As a band, you’ll be getting £70 per gig, which means you’ll get a total of £560 for the tour. Frenzy’s share of the cost of the coach and the rooms will be about £250, so that’ll give you a profit of over £300 for eight one-hour sessions. That’s £75 each.”

They rubbed their hands at the amount. Jag worked over forty hours in a local warehouse and earned less than fifty quid a week.

“Also,” Simon went on, “you’ll be able to sell some of your tapes there. But you’ll have to give twenty percent of the proceeds to the tour organiser.”

Muzza smiled. “And that would be you, I presume?”

Simon smiled back. “I am one of the organisers, yes. How much do you make on the tapes usually?”

Muzza answered. “We sell them for three pounds each. For every ten we sell, Jag gets twelve quid and the rest of us get six each.”

Simon, obviously surprised by this, turned to face Jag, who felt a little embarrassed under his gaze.

“Jag writes all the songs, so it’s only fair. If we had a record deal, he’d be the one who got the royalties for writing the songs.”

“And you’re all happy with this arrangement?”

Before Jag could say anything, Muzza answered. “Yeah, we are. In fact, giving Jag a bigger cut of the cassettes was my idea, not his.”

“Fair enough then, but what about the cover versions you do? I remember you playing *Long Tall Sally* and *Come Together* when I saw you in Stockport.”

Jag answered this one. “We don’t put cover versions on our tapes. That way we’re not likely to get sued by the people who own the rights to those songs.”

Simon produced an envelope from the inside pocket of his suit jacket. “Here are the contracts I’ve had drawn up. I suggest you all take them home, have a read and get them signed and returned to my office before we leave on the bus on Wednesday.”

Biff looked surprised. “Before *we* leave on the bus? Are you saying you’ll be travelling with us?”

Simon smiled again. “Oh yes. I wouldn’t miss this for the world.” With that, he left the room and all the band members looked at each other.

Once again Biff summed up how all the band felt. “Fucking Hell. He’s done alright, eh? I mean — he’s still a cunt, but he’s done alright.”

* * * *

Muzza’s brother, Graham, was kind enough to take the band and their gear to the Salford bus depot on Wednesday morning. Although the coach was over ten years old, it was still in good condition and was a large fifty two-seater. The members of Fresh Scabs were already at the depot when Frenzy arrived. With each musician overseeing the storage of his own equipment, they all introduced themselves to each other as they moved up and down the bus. Jag had been right about the band’s identity. He recognised the bass player from when he’d seen The Buzzcocks with The Scabs as support act.

There was limited storage capacity in the bag-hold spaces down the side of the bus, so only the drum kits and some of the amps were put in there. All guitars and the rest of the amps stayed on the bus, wedged between the seats. They were stowed strategically so that the passengers would be spread out throughout the bus, rather than all the people at the front and all the gear at the back. Just as Graham’s van was pulling out of the depot, a white minibus with a Liverpool phone number written on the side pulled into the vacant bay next to the coach.

The doors opened and the members of Gash stepped out. They were all dressed in jeans and t-shirts and although a couple of them had their hair spiked, none was wearing punk make-up.

Muzza elbowed Jag in the ribs as one of the girls walked past him with a smile. “I wouldn’t mind getting acquainted with *her* gash.”

Everyone introduced themselves. The girls all spoke with strong Liverpudlian accents. They had a couple of guys with them, possibly roadies to set up the gear, or maybe boyfriends who didn’t like the idea of their other halves spending a week and a half with a dozen horny men.

Simon emerged from the bus depot office and approached them by the side of the bus. “Just off the phone to Daryl, who manages The Riot.

They're meeting us in Stoke. Seemed pointless them coming all the way from London to Manchester, just to head back south again."

Everyone boarded the coach and the driver started the engine. The forty-odd mile trip to Stoke seemed to pass pretty quickly, with everyone in good spirits yet quite reserved because of all the strangers. Even Wood was restrained. It took him almost fifteen minutes before he ventured down the bus to sit with one of the blond women from Gash.

* * * *

The club in Stoke turned out to be a large room above a pub called The Wheatsheaf. The Riot had already got their gear set up at the back of the stage. It had been decided by the organisers that the running order of support acts would change throughout the tour. Tonight it was Fresh Scabs opening, followed by Frenzy. Gash would appear just before the main act. The Riot wouldn't be on stage until midnight and their band members were nowhere to be seen.

It took the support acts over an hour to set up their gear, and each band was given a time slot to come and do a sound-check. A guy from the club set up the PA system and checked how many vocal mics each band would need. There were over five hours before they were due on stage. When Muzza realised the pub downstairs didn't serve food, he announced to the other bands that Frenzy was going for something to eat and anyone was welcome to join them.

After a bit of debating, two of the guys from Fresh Scabs joined them, and so did two of the girls from Gash, along with their two roadies-or-boyfriends. They found a suitable pub less than a hundred yards away.

"Okay then," Muzza said. "Two pints of lager, a pint of Guinness and a rum and black, please mate." He knew his own band's order well enough. He turned to the others and pointed to the barman. "Give the man your orders, people."

One of the girls came over to Muzza and Jag as they read the menu. "Hiya guys, I'm Mindy."

Jag smiled and nodded, and Muzza held out his huge hand. "Muzza. This is Jag, and over there is Biff. I don't know where Wood's got to, probably hiding in the bogs until someone else has paid for the beer."

Mindy laughed. Her Scouse accent was so strong Jag was reminded of the sitcom *The Liver Birds*, which had first showed when he was a kid

and was still running. She beamed round at them all. “Why don’t we set up a tab and then split it when we’ve all eaten?”

Muzza nodded. “Sounds like a plan. I don’t know about you lot, but I’m going to go for the steak pie and chips.”

It turned out to be a pleasant afternoon. They ate, drank and got to know the others they’d be spending ten days with. It turned out the two guys accompanying Gash were just there as roadies-come-bouncers.

Mindy explained their presence to Muzza and Jag. “We’ve had quite a few instances of twats from the audience jumping up on stage and trying to grab us.”

“We get that, too,” Jag said. “They usually want to punch Wood in the face.”

She laughed. “Yeah — well, they usually try to grab our tits and dry-hump us from behind.”

Muzza shrugged. “Sorry about that. I promise I won’t do it again.”

Mindy slapped him on the leg. “I suppose we bring it on ourselves. Most of our songs are about sex, and we do abuse the fact we’re women playing to a predominantly male crowd. But still...” She shrugged. “If I’m going to get felt up and dry humped, I like to choose who’s going to do it.”

Muzza nodded. “So those lads over there are your boyfriends?”

Mindy shook her head. “No. Jan over there used to go out with John, the one with the ’tache, but that was last year. They’re just our mates.”

A couple more rounds were consumed before they made their way happily back to The Wheatsheaf to prepare for the gig.

* * * *

Wood and Biff were still in the dressing room when Fresh Scabs opened the evening’s entertainment, but Jag and Muzza had positioned themselves near a pillar to one side of the mosh pit. Jag liked their sound; two guitars, bass and drums. The bass player took lead vocals and the drummer did backing vocals. They played about a 50-50 mix of original songs and covers. The audience, which was still fairly small, seemed to enjoy the covers more, which Jag thought must be annoying for the band. There was a fifteen minute gap between bands, and by the time Frenzy opened their set, the audience had doubled in size. The band rattled through

their repertoire and every song seemed to be well received. The crowd quickly learned to sing along with the words of the chorus of one song:

*What's the point if the feeling's dead?
What's the point if you don't give head?
What's the point if I can't play rough?
What's the point? You can just fuck off!*

They left the stage feeling pretty good about their performance, and twenty minutes later were changed into dry clothes and ready to watch Gash. When the stage lights came up Jag was taken aback by their appearance. The girls were all dressed in short skirts, ripped fishnets, Doc Marten boots and tight-fitting vests. None of them was wearing a bra. Their make-up was way over the top; thick eyeliner, gaudy eye shadow and lipstick, hair spiked up and spray-dyed in reds, greens, purple. Jag didn't recognise them from the girls on the bus and he had to ask Muzza which ones they'd spent the afternoon in the pub with.

"That's Mindy on left-hand guitar. Must be a wig, 'cos her hair wasn't that long four hours ago." Muzza studied the others. "And the other one, Jan, she's on drums."

The two roadies who doubled as bouncers were visible at the side of the stage. The band started playing and the crowd started to leap about. Jag liked the look of the bass player. She was tiny, about five-two and really petite. As she played the bass she bounced about the stage, never looking at the audience. It was Mindy's fellow guitarist who stepped up to the mic and took lead vocals.

*I woke up this morning in a stranger's place
I was wet between the legs and had a smile on my face*

The crowd cheered. Muzza leaned over to shout into Jag's ear over the noise. "Why can't you write classy lyrics like that?"

"How about '*I woke up this morning in a stranger's bed, I was sore up the arse and had a bag on my head*'?"

Muzza laughed out loud. "Yeah, I can just see Wood singing that."

Jag thought Gash put on a good show, but he was a little disappointed with their sound. Considering they'd an extra guitar compared to Frenzy, their sound was not as full. Basically, both guitars seemed to be doing rhythm. He thought they needed a few lead fills to break it up. He

liked the bass riffs, but suspected that was mainly because he liked the look of the girl playing them.

* * * *

By the time The Riot got on stage, the place was heaving. Jag liked a lot of their songs and was impressed by them all as musicians. They were a very tight three-piece and reminded him of *The Jam*. The bass player and guitarist took turns in singing lead, and all the songs had a good beat. Their drummer was particularly good, with loads of Keith Moon-type fills and rolls.

Mindy and the bass player Jag fancied came over to stand by them. Both girls had put black t-shirts over their vests. They still had the full make-up and mini skirts on, but then so did most of the women in the audience.

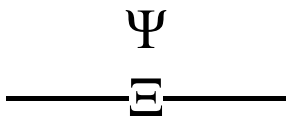
“Lads, this is Debbi,” Mindy shouted between songs.

Muzza, Jag and Biff all smiled in greeting, then Wood draped his arm around her shoulder. “Alright, love?”

Jag was unimpressed. “Fucking cockney wanker,” he muttered in Muzza’s ear.

Debbi shrugged off Wood’s arm and glared at her friend. Obviously it had been Mindy’s idea to come over to stand with the lads from Frenzy.





Chapter Three

The following night they played in a seedy club in Birmingham. Frenzy opened and there were several fights amongst the crowd. Gash was next up, and their roadies were called into action several times as numerous members of the audience climbed onto the stage. The Riot didn't get to finish their set because the police came and made the club management cut the power. Over a dozen punks were arrested, and it was obvious to Jag and Muzza most of these kids had taken something more than alcohol.

Although none of the girls from Gash had come out of the dressing room to watch the other bands, they all came out to watch the police clear out their audience. Debbi was standing next to Jag as they watched two policemen drag a screaming and kicking punk with a blue Mohawk and numerous piercings towards the exit. Even with an officer restraining each arm, the youth still managed to kick the glass panel next to the door, the impact of his boot causing a star-crack in the reinforced sheet.

“What a fucking dick,” Debbi said.

Jag looked sideways at her and smiled. “Yeah. Total twat.”

* * * *

Later that night, Jag lay in bed thinking his first verbal exchange with Debbi was hardly earth-shattering. Still, at least they'd agreed on something. Muzza was fast asleep in the other twin bed in their small hotel room, and he let out a machine-gun fart in his sleep. Jag pressed his face into the pillow and tried to pretend he was somewhere else.

* * * *

As Frenzy tuned up for their sound-check the following afternoon, Biff revealed they had a new fan. “You'll never guess what — Beastly asked to borrow my Walkman last night. Said he wanted to listen to one of our tapes.”

Muzza laughed. “Hope he fucking paid for it.”

“Minus his twenty percent,” Wood added.

Towards the end of the song, Jag broke the second string on his guitar. As the others headed off in search of a pub, Jag told Muzza he was going to stay and change all his strings, and would try and find them later. As he sat at the side of the stage, Gash came out and started to do their sound-check. By the time they’d tuned up and started, Jag had all six new strings on. He tuned up and quickly worked out the chords of the song they were playing, then turned his amp on. As Gash played the latter half of their song, Jag added a few lead-fills and broken chords on the half-beat, just to give a fuller sound.

The lead singer—who Jag now knew was called Kelly—smiled and nodded to him, saying ‘I like that, keep playing’ between her own lines. Jag carried on, and added even more intricate licks as he got to know the song’s structure. After the song ended, Kelly, Mindy and Debbi all came to stand around where he sat.

“That was really good,” Mindy said. “I can’t believe the difference you made to the song.”

Jag shrugged, a little embarrassed. He’d only been jamming to get his strings stretched ready for later.

“Show us what you did.” Debbi looked straight at him.

Jag felt his stomach flutter, which was an odd feeling for him. “I just played a few fills in the gaps, that’s all.”

“Yeah, but what were they?”

Jag placed his left hand on the fret board. “Just messing around, hitting notes in the chords.” He played the chord riff of the song while damping down the sound using the palm of his right hand on the strings as he hit them with the plectrum. “The chords are just G, E minor, C and D right?” As he ran through the chord changes, he started to introduce single or double notes between hitting the chords. “If you play different inversions of the chords, just pick a couple of notes from each, slightly off the beat to fill in the gaps.” He looked from one to the other, his gaze finally settling on Debbi. “Doesn’t matter if you play it differently each time. Let’s face it, the crowds we play to are hardly ever listening to these parts of the songs at all.”

Debbi smiled, and Jag really liked what he saw. She had dark brown eyes and very white teeth.

Mindy broke the spell. “Where are the rest of your lot?”

Jag looked around. “They went to get something to eat, but I’d bust a string, so I said I’d maybe catch them up. Or just grab a booty or something.”

Debbi went to lean her bass against her amp and walked back over to where Jag was still sitting. “I’m just going to walk down into town and grab a sandwich if you want to come. I need to find a phone box and call home, but that’ll only take a minute.”

Jag smiled and put his own guitar down. “Yeah, that’d be great.”

* * * *

Jag and Debbi talked freely about their respective bands and the music that had inspired them to learn to play guitar in the first place.

“I learned to play classical guitar at school,” Debbi told him. “I could read music and everything. Then when I was about fifteen I saw Suzi Quatro on Top of the Pops, and I pestered my parents until they bought me a bass guitar. I thought she looked so sexy playing bass.”

Jag laughed but didn’t admit he used to masturbate thinking about Suzi Q when he was a teenager. “I have older brothers,” he explained. “So all through the sixties when I was a kid, I’d be listening to The Beatles, The Stones, The Hollies, The Who, The Kinks, stuff like that. When I bought my first guitar I just worked my way through the *Beatles Complete* chord book, starting on the songs with three chords, and when I could play them I’d choose songs with four or five chords. I’d try them in other keys to learn more chords. Then I got into Neil Young and learned a lot of his songs. Then I started writing a few things myself.”

Jag found Debbi easy to talk to. He realised he was telling her things he’d never told anyone else before – mainly because nobody else had ever asked. “We had a glam-rock band in school. We used to do Gary Glitter covers.”

Debbi laughed out loud. “I bet you looked great in your sparkly sequined suit.”

“Then suddenly everyone was playing disco stuff and I didn’t like any of that shit. Punk was like a breath of fresh air, so as soon as I heard it, me and Muzza started the band.”

“You write all your band’s songs, don’t you?”

He looked at her, surprised she knew. “Yeah.”

She nodded and smiled again. “They’re good. I bought one of your tapes after the first gig. Been listening to it.”

Jag was pleased she liked his songs. “Thanks. Who does the writing in your band?”

“Kelly writes some of them, and me and Mindy write some together.”

Jag nodded. “I like the fact you play your own stuff. I’m not a big fan of cover versions – they’re for people who want to play in pubs forever.”

Debbi laughed and stopped walking when she spotted a phone box. “Right, I just need to call home.” She looked around, saw a café and pointed to it. “Want to go get us a table in there?”

Jag headed off and found a seat by the window. He watched Debbi as she talked into the handset. He thought she looked agitated. She was moving her free hand as if trying to get some point across to whoever she was talking to. Probably her boyfriend, he thought, who doesn’t like her being so far away with all us undesirables. Jag saw she was very animated by the end of the call, and after hanging up she stayed in the phone box for a few seconds, wiping her eyes with her sleeve.

Debbi joined him in the café, and they spent the next hour chatting about all aspects of music. Jag was embarrassed when he described the outfits he’d worn in the glam-rock band at school. She laughed at him and told him she’d auditioned to join a male punk band simply because she fancied the lead singer. Then she spoiled the story for Jag by revealing the singer had taken her out for a drink after the audition. He’d got her pissed, shagged her, then revealed the original bass player had decided to rejoin the band.

Jag and Debbi were the last ones back, and everybody cheered when they walked in. The two of them looked at each other and shrugged. It seemed everyone had been talking about them while they were out.

Jag went to re-tune the new strings, then wandered along to the dressing room to join the rest of the band.

Biff was walking around in just a very small pair of underpants. “Have you shagged that Debbi, then?”

“Yes, Biff. I had her over the counter in *Chatwins* while she nibbled on a Danish pastry.”

“We could have doubled up as a foursome.” Biff grinned and rearranged his crotch. “I reckon her mate fancies me.”

Muzza said, “Yeah, you’d make a great couple. *Dork & Mindy*.”

Everyone else laughed, and Biff looked hurt. “Oi, fuck off.”

* * * *

The Friday night session went well, with good performances from all four bands and no fighting in the crowd. Jag was amazed when Simon asked him how many more copies of their tape they’d brought with them.

Jag shook his head. “None. We gave you the hundred and fifty we had.”

“Well we’ve only got about a dozen left, so if you can get some more for tomorrow night, that’d be good.”

“Wow.” Jag tried not to show he was impressed. “We usually shift about ten after each gig.”

Jag went to see Muzza, excited. “Beastly just said we need more tapes,” he told him. “The master tape’s still in the studio. If I phone Ian to ask him to run off a couple of hundred copies in the morning, d’you think your Graham will drive them down here before tomorrow night? Tell him we’ll pay for his petrol and time.”

Muzza was nodding. “Yeah, I’m sure he’ll be up for that.”

By the time Jag and Muzza had changed and cleared up the dressing room, the club was empty except for staff clearing up the mess while the stage was being stripped of the gear. They’d agreed to leave it all in a locked store room overnight and pack it into the bus first thing next morning. When Jag went to tell Simon about his plan to get the tapes, he found him deep in conversation at a table with Wood. They both seemed embarrassed at being seen together, as if Jag had caught them doing something wrong. Back in their hotel room later, Jag told Muzza about Simon and Wood’s reaction to him finding them together.

“Well,” Muzza said, “maybe Beastly’s a shirt-lifter and fancies him. I heard that queer posh blokes like a bit of rough.”

Jag laughed. “Yeah. He may well have his middle-class lips around Wood’s cock at this very minute.”

Muzza pulled a face. “What a fucking horrible image that is. I’ll be having nightmares about it.”

* * * *

The Saturday morning was bright and sunny. All the bands loaded their gear onto the bus in good spirits. Debbi was wearing a black vest top, tight-fitting faded blue jeans and green canvas deck-shoes with no socks. She wore no make-up and her short dark brown hair was shiny and free of gel. Jag knew she was twenty-two, but thought she looked much younger. She caught him looking at her as she carried her guitar bag out the back door of the club and smiled at him.

Nick, the guitarist from Fresh Scabs, saw her smile at Jag. "You jammy bastard. She's a bit of alright, eh?"

Jag nodded and made his way onto the bus. They stopped at a greasy-spoon for breakfast, nearly everyone ordering a full English. After they'd eaten, Jag and Muzza went in search of a phone to call Ian and Graham to arrange the tapes. There was a phone box on the street corner and Debbi was just coming out of it. Jag thought she looked worried, but she smiled when she saw him. He wondered what was going on with her but hesitated to ask, knowing it was none of his business.

They got to the venue in Coventry around lunchtime. Once the gear was set up, Mindy asked Jag if he'd help her with a few of the things he'd shown her yesterday. He spent almost an hour just jamming with Mindy, Kelly and Debbi while the rest of his band sat around in the club, drinking and chilling out. As had become the routine, the guys from The Riot were nowhere to be seen. They travelled in their own van, and usually slept in a different hotel. Jag felt pretty sure they wouldn't be sharing tiny rooms and body gases in small crappy guest houses like the rest of them. But in fairness, they were the headline act.

After Mindy had mastered a few fills, Debbi picked up a six-string guitar and played a couple of chords and a bit of a riff. Jag watched her, amazed at how small her hands looked on the fret-board. He was just wondering what they'd look like on his dick when he realised she was talking to him.

"Sorry, what?" he asked.

She smiled like she knew exactly what he'd been thinking. "I said this is something I've been playing with for a while, but I can't make it into a song."

"Play it again."

“Oh my God,” Mindy shouted out to everyone in the room. “These two are quoting *Casablanca* at each other now!”

Debbi laughed and kicked her friend on the leg. “Piss off, yer cheeky cow.” Then she smiled at Jag and he realised everyone else had also noticed how well he and Debbi seemed to be getting along. They played together for the rest of the afternoon, Jag helping Debbi and Mindy to get the bits they already had into a song structure. He took the basic chords and added a few extra notes to make a catchy riff.

“You can play this as the bass line,” he told Debbi, then looked to Kelly. “You play the chords. Have a bit of distortion on your amp and hit the strings with a down-up-down-down rhythm, like this.”

Kelly nodded and tried to repeat what she’d been shown. Jag played along with her, and his version sounded so much better. She looked at him. “What do you do that I can’t?”

Jag smiled. “Have a piss standing up?”

Mindy squealed. “I can do that!”

Kelly frowned at Mindy. “Ignore her. I mean with the chords. We’re both playing the same chords, but yours sounds so much better.”

Jag shifted a little, feeling the heat in his cheeks. “Could just be the guitar. This has Humbuckers and they sound much better than single coil pick-ups.” But they all knew he was just being polite.

Mindy nudged Debbi. “Ooh, what else can he do with his fingers, eh?”

Debbi shrugged an apology at Jag that made him grin back at her.

* * * *

Graham arrived while Jag was still showing Mindy some fills and turn-arounds to add to her song. He left the girls to go and thank Graham and pass the tapes on to Simon. Then it was time to get ready for the performance. During Frenzy’s spot, Jag realised Wood wasn’t singing the right words to a couple of the songs. At first he wondered if Wood was pissed or had done too much speed, but it soon became obvious he was singing something completely different. Jag glanced at Muzza, who was obviously just as confused. The audience didn’t seem to notice, and they got a rapturous applause when they left the stage.

Back in the dressing room, Jag turned on Wood. “What the fuck were you bleating about during those last two songs?”

Wood shrugged. “Si asked me to try a couple of alternative lyrics to see how they sounded.”

Jag looked at Muzza, confused, then back at Wood. “Si?”

“Yeah, Si. Simon. Beastly. He thought they needed to be less biting, like if we want to record them for a commercial market.”

“If you want to sing his words, I suggest you get him to write some fucking tunes as well, 'cos you're not singing that shite to my tunes.” Jag felt the lyrics of the affected songs were some of his best, particularly *Wasting My Time* which he'd written about his job in the warehouse. But he suspected the two songs Simon had chosen to write alternative lyrics for were the ones in which Jag and Muzza didn't sing backing vocals or harmonies.

“I thought they were—”

Jag grabbed Wood by the throat. “They are not going in my fucking songs. If you want to sing his songs, then write some other tunes and we'll give them a go and see what we all think. But if you can't do that, why not fuck off and sing them somewhere else and I'll get another puppet to sing my songs in this band.”

The room was suddenly quiet, everyone watching the two.

Wood probably could've taken Jag in a fight, but everyone knew Muzza would step in if he tried anything. Wood held his hands up. “Look, I only did what Simon asked. He said he wants to get us a record deal, and that he thought the new lyrics may help.”

Jag released Wood's shirt and stepped back. “Well he can fuck off. You tell him that.” As Jag headed towards the door, he heard Biff break the silence in the room.

“Fucking Hell. That's much more like a real punk band – we must be on our way to the big time.”

Jag was drinking at the bar with Graham by the time Muzza joined them. They all got pissed and Mindy and Kelly joined them later. There was no sign of Debbi. Jag kept looking around for her at discreet intervals and finally Mindy caught him at it.

“Debbi's gone back home for a couple of days. We've no gig tomorrow, so her dad drove down for her. He'll drive her to Leicester on Monday.”

Jag was more than a little disappointed, but tried not to show it.

Mindy gave him a hug. “There’s a bit of a problem at home. Her brother’s in some sort of trouble and the police are involved. But now he’s been beaten up and is in hospital. I’m sure she’d rather be here, though. I can see how you two are getting on.”

Jag was pleased to hear it. The missing him part, that was, not the beaten-up-brother part. Muzza passed him another pint of Guinness which made Jag even happier. He stayed at the bar and chatted with Graham for the rest of the night, finding that they were to become temporary roommates while Muzza took advantage of Debbi’s absence to carry out some inter-band relations of his own in Mindy’s room.

There was no gig on Sunday so Muzza and Mindy had the use of her hotel room all day long. Jag went for a long walk to shake off the worst of his hangover then went to breakfast with Graham before he left for Manchester. Biff had pulled some young thing the previous night and gone back to her place; Wood was nowhere to be seen, which suited Jag fine.

With Graham gone, Jag spent the afternoon in his room reading the Sunday papers. He fell asleep and didn’t wake up until almost nine in the evening. He didn’t bother getting anything to eat, just took a shower and got back into bed. He started thinking about Debbi, and was surprised when he got a full erection. Although it would have been pleasant to give himself some release, he resisted the urge. He decided the next time he shot his load it was going to be because of what he was doing with Debbi.





Chapter Four

Monday evening's gig was not as good as Friday and Saturday's had been. The audience was smaller and a little more subdued, the lack of enthusiasm probably passing on to the bands themselves. But Jag and Wood seemed to be getting on okay, and Wood sang the correct words this time. Gash played okay, Mindy introducing a few more of the things Jag had shown her into the set. Debbi kept smiling at Jag as she played along, and he felt that tonight was going to be the night.

The Riot finished the gig with a song Jag hadn't heard before and he thought it was excellent. One of their roadies told him it was a new song they'd just finished writing, and Jag wished he'd written it.

He was back by the bar when Debbi found him. She'd showered after her set and only applied a little mascara and lipstick instead of the full punk make-up. Her hair was still wet, and she had on a red vest, short denim skirt and black canvas pumps. Her legs were bare, making Jag think once again how young she looked. When the DJ started playing records, she had to stand really close so they could hear each other.

When *Sound of the Suburbs* started up, she pulled him towards the floor. "Oh I love this song, come and dance."

Jag really liked it, too. As the lead singer did his lines, he and Debbi were moshing away.

Same old boring Sunday morning old man's out—

Debbi and Jag looked at each other and shouted along with the backing vocals, "*Washing the car!*"

They supplied backing vocals for the second line, "*While it lasts!*" For the rest of the verse they jumped around, crashing into the people next to them. At the short silence before the chorus, Debbi pulled Jag close and they both sang along.

"This is the sound; this is the sound of the suburbs."

Debbi pulled him against her in time with the beat.

“This is the sound; this is the sound of the suburbs.”

Her body was soft and firm at the same time. She was looking straight into his eyes and their faces were almost touching. As she bumped against him in time to the beat, he realised he had a hard-on. Debbi obviously knew it as well, and she kept pushing herself against it.

At the second verse she moved away from him and reverted to her pogo dancing, only looking back at him when she joined in with the backing vocals at the end of each line. Jag was in considerable discomfort as he tried to pogo with a hard-on. Then they were back together again for the second chorus, bumping in time to the beat.

As the guitar solo started, Debbi grabbed Jag’s hand and dragged him off the dance floor. She led him to a small alcove round the back of the stage, pushed him up against a wall, stood on her tip-toes and kissed him. Suddenly their hands were all over each other. She ripped open his jeans; he pulled her vest up, revealing her small, pert boobs. Her nipples were hard between his fingers. She held his dick and wanked him. He spun them both around so she had her back against the wall and bent down, hitching up her short skirt. She opened her legs and pulled her knickers to one side. He bent his knees slightly and entered her and, as he straightened his legs, lifted her off the floor. She wrapped both her legs around his waist and arms around his neck. He fucked her hard and she came almost immediately, groaning and pulling at his hair. When he felt her tighten around him he held still for a few seconds, his cock buried deep inside her. She looked into his eyes as her orgasm ebbed away and they held eye contact as he started to move again. He kept the pace slow, and she started to wriggle on him, swaying her hips in little circles, milking him. Jag realised he too was close — really close.

He needed to ask about contraception, but didn’t want to break the spell. Withdrawing was not going to be an easy option because he was holding her off the floor. “Is it safe to come inside you?”

She nodded, continuing her circle moves. He started to fuck her harder and she started to claw and scratch at his back. At first he thought it was for his benefit, but then felt her contracting around him again as she reached a second orgasm. He came, shooting inside her as he slammed her against the wall. When he’d finished, he realised his legs were too weak to hold her weight, and he lowered her until her feet touched the floor. Her eyes were closed and her mouth slightly open. For the first time in years,

Jag felt he'd shared more than just body fluids. Debbi opened her eyes then leaned forward, kissing him gently on the mouth.

* * * *

A few minutes later, they were stood at the bar. They no longer had the energy to dance. Muzza and Mindy joined them, Mindy guessing immediately what had taken place.

"You've got a smile to your face, Debbi."

Debbi smiled broadly. "Piss off."

Mindy slapped Jag's arm. "About fucking time. I was beginning to think you might be queer."

Jag laughed and looked at Muzza. "What *do* you see in this woman?"

"Cheeky little fucker!" Mindy laughed and slapped his arm again, winking at Muzza. "He knows when he's onto a good thing. Speaking of which, how about you two have your room tonight, and me and him have ours?"

Jag looked at Debbi, who nodded enthusiastically.

Back in their room, Jag and Debbi stripped each other off and went straight into the shower. Debbi stood with her hands on her head while Jag washed her all over. He dropped to his knees and washed her gently between the legs, then she took the soap and washed him. By the time she'd cleaned his upper body and legs he had a hard-on. She slowly soaped and rinsed his dick, then held it in her hand as she led him out of the shower to the bed. They didn't bother drying themselves. She pushed him onto his back and took him into her mouth. Jag let out a cry as she moved her head up and down. After less than a minute he eased her head away, lifted her on top of him and kissed her. Debbi put a knee on either side of his waist and squatted over him, lowering herself onto his dick. She was slow and gentle, making a show of watching his face as she rode him. When he was just about to come, Debbi pressed down harder to get the friction she obviously needed on her clit to help her over the edge, letting out small muffled cries as she came. Then Jag released, flooding her insides. She leaned forward, holding him close.

They started to get cold so slipped under the sheets and lay in each others arms, talking. She asked about the band members and their nicknames.

“Muzza’s my best mate,” he said. “We’ve known each other since primary school. His real name’s Paul Musgrove. Biff’s really Stefan, and his last name is a Polish one beginning with Z. Apparently he’s had the nickname since high school, but I don’t know where it comes from. Wood’s last name is Woodward. I’m pretty sure his first name’s either Jonathan or John.”

Debbi was kissing the side of his neck. “And where does ‘Jag’ come from?”

“If you keep doing that you’ll see for yourself.”

She laughed and slid her hand down from his chest to his crotch.

“Oh, I already know where *you* come from. I meant the name.”

“Ah,” he said, enjoying her fingers stroking him. “It’s an abbreviation of Jaguar, because I’m like a wild cat in bed.”

Debbi scrunched up her nose. “No, it’s definitely not that.”

Jag pretended to be hurt. “Maybe it’s an abbreviation of Jaguar because I’m a fast and powerful ride, like a performance car.”

Debbi smiled, shaking her head.

“Okay, it’s actually my initials. James Andrew Gould — JAG. It started at school and just stuck with me.”

“That I *can* believe. So...James? You don’t look like a James. I’ll call you Jag – I like that.”

He smiled at her. “Good.”

“What about the songs you write — where do they come from?”

“Everywhere.” He shrugged. “You write songs as well, so you know what it’s like. Something happens and you start to get words sticking in your head. Riffs come to me all the time, especially when I’m out walking. When I get back I work them out on the guitar and write them down.”

Debbi nodded. “Tell me about the song you wrote about the girl you all shared.”

“Who told you about that?” Jag looked at her, surprised.

“Someone told Mindy, but I don’t know who.”

“Well for a start, we didn’t share her. She was just a young girl who liked to screw strangers.”

Debbi recited the opening lines: “*Little shady lady Ellen O’Ride, She’s got all the boys trying to touch her inside.*”

Jag looked at her, smirking. “Okay then, tell me about your song. *‘I woke up this morning in a stranger’s place, I was wet between the legs and*

had a smile on my face.’”

Debbi laughed out loud. “Yeah, that’s one of mine. I wrote that about a one-night stand. A later verse was going to be, *‘I woke up this morning in a stranger’s place. I had his head between my legs and his cum on my face.’*” She burst out laughing at his expression of shock. “I was joking! Maybe...”

He dug his fingers into her ribs, and she squealed with laughter. Then he slid his hands up her front, his fingers finding her nipples. Her laughing stopped and she kissed him, pulling him on top of her. As he entered her she moaned into his mouth and wrapped her legs around the back of his. Nothing more was said as they made love. It was slow and gentle, and shortly afterwards they fell asleep in each other’s arms.

* * * *

The second gig in Leicester was at the local polytechnic. Although they were staying in the same guest-house for both nights, they still had to move their gear and set up in the students’ union bar. Once their kit was assembled, Biff and Wood both disappeared in the hope of getting off with a couple of students. Muzza and Jag waited around for Gash to do their sound-check, but when they hadn’t appeared after an hour Muzza insisted he needed to eat. They walked off campus and found a pub half a mile away.

Muzza had a mouth full of burger but still started a conversation. “So, you and Debbi... Going alright, is it?”

Jag smiled and shrugged. “Yeah,” he admitted. “I really like her.”

Muzza put down his pint. “Fuck me! For you, that’s almost like you’re considering proposing.”

Jag laughed. “Bollocks. I just enjoy being with her, that’s all.”

“You mean you enjoy being ‘in’ her.”

“No. Well, yeah. But I like talking to her. She’s nice. Don’t make such a big deal of me actually liking someone. What about you and Mindy?”

A big smile spread over Muzza’s face. “She’s a fucking dream – absolutely filthy. D’you know what she did—?”

“Stop there!” Jag held up his hand. “I’ll need to look her in the face later, and I can’t do that if you tell me loads of stuff you’ve done to her.”

“She did most of it to me. When she was blowing me off she stuck her finger right up—”

“No, no, no.” Jag held his ears.

Muzza shrugged. “Sorry.” He picked up his burger and put it to his mouth, but quickly added, “I shot my load straight away.”

Jag dropped his own burger and looked away, shaking his head.

Muzza chuckled. “Good job you didn’t order mayonnaise on that.”

Jag laughed too, and downed his pint. “Same again?”

* * * *

When they got back to the poly, there was still no sign of Gash. Jag had been hoping he and Debbi could get a taxi back to the guest-house and spend a couple of hours in bed. He saw the girls’ instruments out of their cases, so they’d obviously done their sound-check while he’d been in the pub. He was just about to ask Muzza if he knew where Debbi and Mindy might be when Simon came to speak to him about tapes. Apparently they’d already sold most of them, so Simon was hoping to take orders and post them on. Jag didn’t know if your average punk student would be prepared to pay three quid up front for something that *might* get posted to them in the future. He suggested asking someone on the student union committee to see if they’d be prepared to sell the cassettes if they could get a few dozen delivered here next week. Simon nodded and went off in search of somebody else to help him get his twenty percent.

Jag didn’t get to see Debbi again until Gash got on stage just before ten. Once again he was shocked at how different she looked in all her punk regalia – but tonight even more so. Her make-up was gaudy, her hair gelled into a mo-hawk and sprayed shocking pink. Instead of fishnet tights she wore ripped black nylon stockings held up by a suspender-belt, revealing an inch of white thigh below her short denim skirt. Her vest-top was hiked up so there was a three-inch band of flesh showing above her skirt, though her bass guitar covered some of it at the front. As Jag watched from the side of the hall, Debbi never once looked in his direction.

Something was wrong.

He remembered her absence during the afternoon and wondered if she’d phoned home and gotten even more bad news about her brother.

There was a thirty-minute interval between Gash finishing their set and Frenzy starting theirs. Jag was already changed into his stage clothes

and waited as long as he could in sight of the door to the room Gash was using, but Debbi didn't come out. He had to make his way to the steps when he heard the crowd cheering as the rest of his band made their way onto the stage. All through the set Jag looked out for Debbi, but she never showed up. It was during The Riot's set that he finally saw her talking to Kelly and their roadies at the far end of the bar. Jag made his way over towards them, and when Debbi spotted him she said something to the others strode towards him, her face grim.

"Hiya," he said. "Is everything alright?"

"No it fucking isn't. I feel like a complete idiot, and I think you're a complete twat."

Jag didn't know what had happened since the last time they'd spoken. "What are you talking about?"

"I don't like being used, and I certainly don't like being part of your fucking games."

He felt like he'd been kicked. "*What?*"

"Why don't you just piss off and leave me alone?" Debbi turned to walk back to her friends, and Jag tried to catch her hand. She snatched it out of his grip. "Fuck off!"

She'd actually *snarled* at him. Stunned, Jag saw her disappear into the mass of people watching the band and when his legs finally decided to work again, he wandered back to the bar. Muzza and Mindy were talking seriously. When Jag reached them, Mindy turned her back and walked away.

"What's happened?" Jag asked his friend.

"Mindy reckons someone's told Debbi you're working your way through their band for a bet."

Jag was horrified. "I'm what? Who told her that?"

Muzza shrugged and shook his head.

"But you told Mindy the truth, right?" Jag asked.

"I told her you didn't fuck women for bets."

Jag's first thought was it must have been Wood. The argument where he'd threatened to replace Wood with another singer was obviously still a sore point. But then again, why would Debbi choose to believe Wood rather than him? Jag downed his drink and told Muzza he was going back to the hotel.

* * * *

Two hours later, Jag was lying awake on his bed when Muzza came into their room.

“You still awake then?”

He sighed. “No, I’m fast asleep and you’re just a fucking ugly nightmare.”

Muzza smiled. “Well, Debbi being back in their room means I don’t get to stay with Mindy.” He rubbed his crotch and raised his eyebrows at Jag. “So, how’d you like to take her place?”

“Fuck off.”

Muzza stripped his shirt off and dropped his leather trousers. “Come on baby, you know you want me...”

“If you don’t go to sleep, I’ll be doing Mindy’s trick. But instead of a nicely manicured middle finger, I’ll be shoving my whole fist up your fat hairy arse!”

Muzza laughed and made his way into the bathroom. He left the door open while he peed, letting out a loud fart as he did so. Jag found it hard to believe it was only twenty four hours since he’d been sharing this bedroom and bathroom with Debbi. He felt numb.

When Muzza came back out of the bathroom, Jag asked him if anything more had been said.

“Yeah. Somebody told Debbi they’d seen Jan coming out of your room on Sunday morning.”

Shock hit him. “Jan their drummer? You’ve got to be fucking kidding me!”

“I told them it was bollocks.”

Jag was angry now. “Why would I want to fuck Jan? She looks like an ugly bloke.”

Muzza laughed. “Yeah, but she’s got huge tits.”

“I don’t like huge tits! I like small tits, good legs, firm arses and pretty faces. Debbi’s got all of those, so if I was sleeping with her, why would I bother chasing Jan?”

Muzza shrugged. “That was before you’d slept with Debbi.”

“I’ve had *nothing* to do with Jan.” Jag found himself almost pleading, desperate to prove his innocence. “Even if Debbi wasn’t on this

tour, I still wouldn't want to sleep with Jan. I'd rather sleep with you, for fuck sake!"

"That's understandable. I'm hot and dirty." Muzza turned suddenly serious, looking as sincere as he ever got. "Look mate, I told Mindy to tell Debbi it was bollocks. She'll come around."

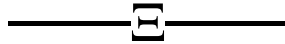
"It's Wood, being a sly cunt. He didn't like me having a go at him the other day." Jag felt himself steaming at the injustice.

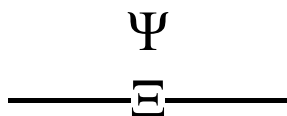
"Can't think why. What's not to like about being told you're a useless fucking puppet? No, seriously, I asked if it was Wood, and Mindy reckons Debbi wouldn't have believed him. It must've been somebody else. Somebody she trusts."

"Why doesn't she just ask Jan?"

Muzza shrugged again. "I dunno. I think those two have some sort of history with blokes. I think Debbi might have fucked one of Jan's boyfriends in the past or something like that."

Jag closed his eyes. "Great. Fucking brilliant."





Chapter Five

The next morning, Muzza and Jag were late for the coach. They'd eaten breakfast in the students' canteen and lost track of time. When they finally boarded the bus, Biff cheered but everyone else was obviously pissed off with them. Muzza gave everyone a wave and blew a kiss to Mindy as he walked past her. Jag could see Debbi sitting just a few rows from the front. She had her head turned to look out of the window. As he passed her seat, he stopped and bent down so he could speak quietly.

"Debbi, can we talk about whatever you've been told? Please?"

She kept her eyes fixed on something on the other side of the car park and didn't acknowledge his presence at all.

Just then the bus started to move, so Jag walked toward the back. As he passed Wood's seat, Jag glared in his direction, but Wood pretended to be absorbed in his copy of NME. Jag dropped into a seat about halfway along the bus and stared out of the window.

Ten minutes into the journey, Jag saw Debbi stand up and walk a little way down towards his seat. His heart beat faster, but she stopped by the lads from Fresh Scabs. "Nick, can we have a quiet word at the back of the bus?"

Jag saw the guitarist stand up and follow her. Debbi didn't look at Jag as she passed him, but Nick gave a shrug that suggested he hadn't a clue what Debbi wanted to chat about. Jag was determined not to turn and watch their faces to try and work out if he was the subject of their conversation. The bus was far too noisy for him to have any chance of eavesdropping, so

rather than torture himself, he just watched the countryside flash past through the window.

Several minutes later Jag realised someone was standing in the aisle at the side of his seat. He turned and saw Debbi looking down at him. Her eyes were cold and hard. She bent at the waist and brought her face to within a few inches of his. Then she opened her mouth. It took Jag a few moments for his mind to tell him what he was seeing.

Debbi's mouth was full of semen.

Her tongue was flat against the base of her mouth, and the off-white liquid brimmed to the level of her bottom lip.

After a few seconds she closed her mouth again and made a show of swallowing. Then she spoke. "Now fuck off, and never speak to me again."

With that she walked back to her seat. Jag's stomach was cold. He felt sick. Nick wandered past a few minutes later, too embarrassed to look at Jag, but probably feeling very happy with the way his morning had turned out.

* * * *

The trip from Leicester to Derby was only thirty miles, and as soon as the coach stopped at the club Debbi disappeared with Kelly and one of the roadies. Mindy waited for Muzza, so Jag headed off for a walk alone. It was a bright warm day and the streets were busy with shoppers. He bought a bottle of cola from a newsagent's and followed a narrow walkway down the side of some shops, finding that it led to a path that ran alongside a stream. Jag walked for fifteen minutes then sat down on a bench.

He couldn't believe what Debbi had done on the coach.

She must have known Nick fancied her, and she'd used Nick to get at him. He drank his cola and watched some ducks swimming in the stream. A riff came into his head. It was aggressive and punchy; angry music to match his mood. He'd write some very cutting lyrics to go with it. Words flooded his head, line after line.

*I wanted to trust her, I wanted to see
If somebody else could mean something to me
She opened her thighs but made me the whore
She swallowed their lies, and a whole lot more*

As Jag made his way back to the club his mind played with different titles for the song he'd probably never bother writing. *Getting Basic with a Bassist. A Flash of Gash. Let it Fester in Leicester. Sound of the Subnormals.* This last one made him think of dancing with Debbi just two nights ago, finding that quiet spot behind the stage where they'd fucked like teenagers. He couldn't believe how quickly everything had disappeared, and felt stupid for feeling the way he did. In reality, Debbi had turned out to be little more than Zoe had been — a fleeting sex partner. He was annoyed at being so upset by the fact they'd only had a brief relationship. As he approached the rear of the club, The Riot's minibus arrived. The guys from the other band waved as they made their way into the club, and another title came to him: *In the Shadow of The Riot.*

* * * *

The audience in Derby was excellent, and Frenzy was the last band on before the main act. Jag had stayed in the dressing room while Fresh Scabs and Gash had done their sets. He didn't particularly want to see Nick, and he'd decided it would be easier all round if he didn't have to see Debbi again. She'd made it as obvious as she could that what they'd shared was well and truly over.

Jag concentrated hard during their set, and he knew everything he played was perfect. He added a few extra licks and all the other band members seemed to notice it, upping their own performances. Wood was at his best, belting out the lyrics of *Wanted Man* like stabbing blows as he bent forward over the edge of the stage, glaring at the crowd. Muzza and Biff never missed a beat, and Jag's Telecaster was a perfect mix of power chords to drive the song and intricate fills to make them interesting. When Jag and Muzza stepped up to their mics to add backing vocals, there seemed to be a strange type of aggression about it all, and the crowd really got into every song. When they left the stage, the crowd kept cheering and stamping their feet until they came back on and played an encore.

Jag took a taxi back to the hotel straight after their set, not even bothering to get changed. Once in his hotel room, he took a shower and went to bed. He fell fast asleep within minutes. This could have been because he'd hardly slept the previous night, or perhaps because he'd drunk a half-bottle of rum during the taxi ride.

* * * *

Muzza and Mindy stood near the side of the bar as the bouncers cleared the club of the last few stragglers. Debbi had been on the other side of the room with the two roadies, but when the guys went to pack up the gear she made her way over towards them. Muzza ordered himself and Mindy another drink, and then raised his eyebrows to Debbi. She smiled and asked for a Bacardi and coke. Muzza ordered her a triple. They all went and sat at a table near the open doors, where the air was cooler and smelt less of stale alcohol and sweaty bodies.

“I know nothing I can say will change anything,” Muzza said to Debbi. “But I need to understand what’s happened. You two seemed to be so right for each other.”

Debbi smiled, but there was little humour in her expression. “Yeah, well. Shit happens all the time.”

Muzza watched her, but didn’t say anything else.

Eventually, Debbi cleared her throat. “I used to see a guy. We were together for almost two years, and I thought *we* were so right for each other as well. But he obviously didn’t feel the same way because it turned out he was fucking other women behind my back for almost the whole time we were together.” She took a long drink and gave another humourless smile. “I must be a fucking lousy shag.”

Muzza didn’t comment on that, although his mind ran through how well her body moved with the beat when she played the bass. “What makes you think Jag did the same?”

“When I was back in Liverpool, he fucked Jan.” Debbi looked at Mindy for support, but none was forthcoming. “John told me about it.”

Muzza was puzzled. “Who’s John?”

“One of our roadies. They were in the next room to us in the hotel, and he said he’d had to listen to you pair grunting and groaning all Saturday night.”

Mindy rubbed Muzza’s thigh. “He’s such an animal.”

Debbi ignored her. “John said he didn’t get any bloody sleep until you’d finally shagged each other to death, and so the following morning he was late for breakfast. As he made his way towards the dining room, he literally bumped into Jan as she came out of yours and Jag’s room. She was

embarrassed about him seeing her, and he said she'd definitely got the post-sex look, and John should know – he went out with her for ages.”

Muzza shook his head briskly. “I don't believe it.”

Debbi shrugged. “He didn't make a big thing about it. He just said he thought I should know. He's nothing to gain, he's just a mate. But he'd heard about Jag's bet to fuck us all, as well. Wouldn't be the first time you lads played around, would it? I know what Ellen O'Ride was all about.”

“There was no bet. That part was probably Wood getting his revenge 'cos Jag called him a 'fucking puppet' and threatened to kick him out of the band.” Muzza thought for a minute. “Why didn't this John tell you about Jan before you and Jag got together?”

Debbi shrugged. “It didn't matter then.”

Muzza shook his head again. “Debbi, I'm not trying to say your mate's lying to you, but I would bet my left bollock that Jag wouldn't go after your drummer.”

“Yeah? Well, I thought the same. I guess he had us both fooled.”

Muzza shrugged. God, she was being hard work. He looked at Mindy, then back at Debbi. “I'll tell you something not many people know,” he said. “When we were at school, Jag went out with one of the girls there. She was called Suzanne, and she was the best looking girl in the whole school. They were really into each other, but when her parents found out about it, they went ballistic. They didn't want their precious girl wasting herself on a lad from where me and Jag grew up. So they decided to move themselves out of Manchester and sent Suzanne to a private school. Jag never got to see her again. Some of her friends reckoned he'd got her pregnant, but Jag said he hadn't. Anyway, a lot of women have been and gone since Suzanne, but I have never known him to say anything nice about any of them.” Muzza nodded at Debbi. “Until you, that is.”

Debbi just gazed back with a blank expression and he couldn't tell if she believed him, or even cared.

He began to feel defeated. “I'm not trying to tell you what to do, but I wish you'd talk to Jan and get her to tell you the truth. I think what you and Jag could have together makes it worth it.”

With that, Muzza kissed Mindy on the cheek and made his way to start to pack up their gear.

* * * *

The journey to Nottingham the following day was uneventful. Jag was on the bus early and sat as far back as he could get without sitting with guitars on his knees. He listened to Neil Young's *Live Rust* on his Walkman, held a magazine, and never looked up at the other passengers during the entire trip.

Once they'd reached their destination, he stayed on the bus until everyone else had gone into the club. Then he left the bus and went for a walk, knowing Muzza would take his amp and guitar inside for him. It was a couple of hours later by the time he got back, and Simon approached him as soon as he walked through the door.

"Jag, can I have a word?"

"What's up?"

Simon looked around, spotted a spare table over to one side. "Let's talk over there." Without waiting for an answer, he walked away.

Jag looked around but the only people in the vast room were strangers, presumably staff from the club. He pulled a chair out and sat down. "Yeah?"

"I've just been speaking to some contacts on the phone. I'd sent them a copy of your tape. They'd like you boys to go and do a demo at their studio in London at the end of the month."

Jag sat back. "Wow!" Really, 'wow' was all he could manage. "What did the others say?"

Simon shook his head. "I've not told them yet. Like I said, I'm just off the phone. They're away getting something to eat."

Jag realised he was smiling.

"But I wanted to tell you first, with you being band leader and all."

Jag was puzzled. "I'm not the band leader. We're all equal."

"That's not how it seems to me. You decide what you play."

"No I don't."

Simon shrugged. "That's not what I heard after Wood tried a few alternative lyrics."

"I think I have every right to decide what words get sung in *my* songs. That's not being the band leader, but the songs I write are my own. If you want to write lyrics, put them to somebody else's tunes."

Simon shrugged. "Fair enough. I was just trying to help."

Jag was instantly defensive. "I need help, do I? Are you saying there's a problem with my lyrics?"

Simon exhaled heavily. "No, that's not what I'm saying. Forget it."

Jag knew if Simon's lyrics were in his songs, then Simon would be entitled to a chunk of the royalties. He suspected this had been the reason behind Simon's sudden urge to be a songwriter, but was too happy about the recording news to confront him.

As Jag pushed his chair back and went to stand, Simon leaned forwards again. "My contacts seem to think that if you're going to get an album out, it'll have to be soon. According to them, punk's had its day. The music world is changing. Synthesisers are where it's at now."

"Yeah, if you're Donna Summer. I think I'll stick with the guitar, thanks."

Simon smiled, got up and walked away. Jag stayed sitting at the table for another twenty minutes. He couldn't believe they were going to record a demo in London. They might actually get to make an album. This was everything he'd dreamed of, and yet he didn't feel quite as thrilled as he should.

The sound of guitars tuning up made him look up. Gash was on stage getting ready to do their sound-check. Jag saw Debbi sitting on her amp, looking anywhere but in his direction. He would've loved to have been able to go and share his news with her. He decided to make himself scarce and let her do her job. He walked out of the front door, sat on the car park wall in the sun and waited for the rest of his band mates to return.

* * * *

That final night, Frenzy, first up and buoyed by the news of an audition in London, played with a lot of energy. They were tight, and even though the club was only half full this early, the crowd seemed to sense this was not an ordinary performance. As soon as the band was back in the dressing room, Jag showered and changed. He pulled Muzza to one side. "Any chance you could do me a favour and get my gear on the bus and back home?"

Muzza looked puzzled. "Why? What are you doing?"

Jag shrugged. "I've taken two weeks off work, so I thought I'd spend the rest of this week wandering round. Never been here before, so I thought I'd have a look. Maybe do a bit of walking in Sherwood Forest."

"You're alright, though?"

Jag laughed. "Course I'm alright, yer fanny. Don't get all fucking touchy-feely and start having periods on me."

Muzza laughed. "Fuck off, I'm just asking. I know you liked her, that's all."

"Yeah. But that doesn't matter now, does it?"

"So, are you leaving after the last-night party?"

"Thought I'd give it a miss, mate. I'm going to find a taxi and get a decent night's sleep in a room for one. I've had enough of sharing my space with your body gases."

Muzza's face split into a wide grin. "Excellent. Looks like Mindy will be getting the sort of send-off she deserves now we have 'a room'."

Jag smiled and slapped him on the arm. "Make her suffer, mate."

He walked out of the club and into the warm night, along the side of the club and right at the end of the street.

A bunch of youths in punk gear stood outside the front door of a pub, evidently being refused entry. A couple of them saw Jag approaching and made their way towards him. Jag recognised the shorter one as the lout who'd been thrown out by the police in Birmingham — the one who'd broken the glass and been the subject of his and Debbi's first conversation. The kid was wearing a t-shirt featuring The Riot.

Jag usually didn't bother getting involved in other people's arguments, but decided to tell the youths they'd be welcomed at the club, and they'd also be able to catch some of the support bands. He walked toward them. "Lads, why don't you —?"

Before he could finish, the taller youth punched him in the face. "Keep your fucking nose out, yer cunt," he snarled.

Jag wished Muzza was with him — he was the best person Jag knew to sort out trouble like this. Jag knew that the wise option would be to walk away. There was no reasoning with these louts. But he was still angry about how things had turned out with Debbi, and maybe this underlying aggression caused him to respond in a way that was out of character. He swung a foot and kicked his attacker in the balls. Then the youth he'd recognised from Birmingham punched him in the stomach and Jag doubled over, winded, his stomach feeling hot and cold at the same time. He dropped to the ground and kicks rained in on his back, legs and arms as he curled himself up on his side. He heard the youths running away, laughing and chanting.

When Jag tried to sit up he felt too weak, the heels of his hands sliding across the pavement without any grip. He rubbed his stomach, which was still hurting, and felt a hot wetness. He realised he was sweating, knew what he'd find when he looked; his palm was covered in blood. The youth hadn't punched him — he'd been stabbed. Jag started to shiver, and just before he blacked out, he saw an elderly man bending over him.

* * * *

Back in the club, Muzza watched Gash from the side of the stage and later Mindy joined him at the bar while Fresh Scabs were doing their set. Muzza was just about to take a sip from his drink when he was punched on the arm. He looked up, ready to hit back twice as hard, and saw his brother Graham grinning at him.

"What the fuck are you doing here?" Muzza asked, smiling broadly himself now.

"Thought I'd come and see your last show," Graham said, nodding at Muzza's glass as he waved a five pound note at one of the bar staff.

"Lager, cheers. You're too late. We were first on tonight." Muzza pointed to Mindy's glass, ordered a Pernod and lemonade for her, and Graham went to get them all a drink.

Everyone from the other bands came to watch The Riot's last show. They were absolutely brilliant, and the entire place was jumping. Muzza danced with Mindy and when he looked over to the other side of the mosh pit, there was Graham with Jan, the drummer from Gash. Suddenly Muzza knew what had happened, and he dragged Mindy off towards the bar.

"What's wrong?" Mindy yelled.

"We need to find your mate!" he bellowed, but the music was too loud for Mindy to hear him.

Muzza stalked around the bar until he saw one of the roadies, "Where's Debbi?"

The guy shrugged. "With Kelly." He pointed towards the mosh pit. "In there somewhere."

Muzza looked into the throng of jumping bodies and knew he'd never find her. He got himself and Mindy another drink and waited until the band finished. As soon as he saw Debbi he hurried over to her, dragging Mindy by the hand behind him.

Debbi saw them coming and the smile disappeared from her face.
“What now?”

“It was my brother Graham,” he said.

“What was?” Debbi looked towards Mindy, who shrugged in equal bemusement.

“It was Graham in our room — mine and Jag’s room, that is. The night you went back to Liverpool, Graham brought down some more of our tapes. He was going to drive back after the show, but I told him he could have my bed, because I knew I’d be in your room with Mindy.” He watched as Debbi digested this information.

Mindy spoke first. “And you’ve only just remembered this now?”

“I forgot all about it. But I’ve just seen him and Jan all over each other. They must have met after the show on Saturday.”

Debbi was shaking her head. “So where did Jag sleep?”

Muzza shrugged. “In his own bed, probably. But he gets up early, and he does a lot of walking. Chances are, as soon as he got up and left, Graham phoned Jan and told her to go to his room.”

Debbi closed her eyes and stayed still for several seconds. When she opened them, she looked extremely sad. “Where’s Jag now?”

Muzza shrugged. “He left as soon as we’d finished our set. He didn’t want to stay for the party. He’s going to stay over here for a couple more days, walking round Sherwood fucking Forest or something.”

Debbi shook her head. “Well, I don’t think there’d be any point in me speaking to him anyway.”

Muzza was shocked. “Are you serious? He really likes you.”

“Not after what I did, he doesn’t.”

“Why? What did you do?”

Debbi smiled a humourless smile. “You don’t want to know. But trust me – he won’t want to see me again.”

Muzza shook his head. “No offence love, but I think I know him a bit better than you do. I’ve known him since I was five and I can assure you — he’s really keen. There may’ve been a lot of women, but there were only two that ever meant anything to him. And you’re one of those.”

Debbi frowned. “I don’t think I will be now.”

Muzza smiled. “You’re wrong. He won’t care what you’ve done. He just cares about how you make him feel. We’re playing in Stockport next

Tuesday night. Come and see us. I promise you, Jag'll be very happy to see you."

Debbi looked uncertainly at Mindy, who squealed and put her arms around her friend's neck. "It's even better than *Casablanca!*"

Debbi smiled and realised she was crying.

* * * *

The following week, Mindy drove Debbi to Stockport in her old Vauxhall Viva. After parking in a multi-storey at the end of the street, they made their way towards the club. As they approached, they saw the 'Show Cancelled' sign on a board on the pavement. Debbi was certain Jag had decided to drop out because he didn't want to see her. When they got inside, there was a DJ playing music and the dance floor was about half full. There was no sign of any of the guys from Frenzy.

The girls got themselves a drink and were just wondering what to do next when Muzza came through the door. He looked awful. He was pale and hadn't shaved in days. His eyes were red-rimmed. The girls made their way over.

Mindy put her arms around him. "What's happened?"

Muzza took a couple of deep breaths. "Jag...Jag was stabbed in Nottingham that last night of the tour."

Debbi's stomach went instantly cold, and she thought she might faint. She couldn't speak.

Mindy was the one to ask. "Is he going to be alright?"

"Dunno. He's in a coma." He shook his head, tears forming in his eyes.

Debbi was dimly aware of the DJ changing records and came sharply back to life as *Sound of the Suburbs* started to blast from the speakers. Tears spilled over. "Which hospital's he in?"

Muzza sniffed. "City Hospital. I'm driving over tomorrow morning if you want to come."

She nodded. "We'll take a guitar so I can play him another song I've been working on. He's bound to wake up and show me a better way to play it."

The three of them stood and listened to the song, moist-eyed, but with hopeful smiles making their way back on their faces.

THE END

About the Author



Delores Swallows has many dirty thoughts, and during his free time he writes them down in the form of stories. Born and bred in the northwest of England, he has a commoner's accent and a bit of a crush on his future queen (Kate, not Camilla!).

His stories often feature petite brunettes, high-heeled shoes and voyeurism. He claims he didn't realise these were obsessions until someone pointed out how often they appear in his work.

Find out more about Delores on his [web site](#), chat on [Twitter](#), or follow his new stories on [Amazon](#). And don't forget to sign up to his [mailing list](#) for a **free story**.

Don't forget your dirty story exclusively available to members of [Delores' mailing list](#).

Also by Delores Swallows



Rolled

She took a sip of wine. "Can I ask you something?"

He sat forward "Yeah."

"It's about me being with Bromley..."

"Oh." He looked deflated, as if resigned to the fact he wouldn't be getting any after all.

"I'm just curious about your feelings. What goes through your mind when you're out here and I'm in the bedroom with Bromley?"

He cast his eyes to the floor. "I try not to think—"

"Come on, don't hold back. For the first time in ages, we're actually talking to each other like we used to. We've had a lovely evening." She adjusted herself in her chair, moving her legs to reveal more of her thighs. "I've even dressed up for you..."

He glanced at her legs, then held her gaze. "I think about how you must look on the bed."

"How do you mean?"

"You know, your face, your body."

Janine was puzzled. "I'm not sure I—"

"I think about your expressions, your body language. I imagine you lying down on the bed and looking up at him." He shrugged, embarrassed.

"You mean when I'm lying on the bed and watching him undress?"

Adam nodded.

"What about when I pass him the condom and watch him roll the rubber down onto his cock?"

"Do you help get him hard?" His voice was little more than a whisper.

She shook her head. “No. By the time he unzips his trousers, he’s got a hard-on.” She saw him swallow, bite his lip.

“And what about you? Does he need to...?” He pushed a shoulder forward in a childish shrug, as if ashamed to use the word *foreplay*.

“No.”

“Why not?”

“I’m always wet enough.”

He nodded, took a gulp of wine.

Janine was enjoying herself. She was wet now, just talking about it. “He dribbles, too. I can see precum all over the head of his cock. It glistens until he rolls the condom on.”

Adam was silent, his eyes a little glazed.

Janine uncrossed her legs, placing both feet on the floor. “When he kneels on the bed, I open my legs for him, like this.” She allowed her knees to fall open. “Do you like me opening my legs for another man?”

He frowned, nodded his head slightly.

She smiled. “At last, you’re being honest. Good.”

Adam put his wine down and slid off the sofa, crawled on his hands and knees across the rug until he was by her feet.

She raised her bum high enough off the chair for him to remove her panties. “Can you imagine my expression when he runs the head of his cock through the wetness of my slit?”



When Janine allows Adam to talk her into visiting a casino to celebrate five years together, she never imagines that a night that starts with so much fun and flirting could end in such despair and debt. Adam doesn't just lose all the money they'd saved, he takes out credit they cannot afford to pay back.

They work extra hours and struggle for a month to save up enough for the first payment. Then, it appears, the casino manager has another way the struggling couple could make the interest payments.

Outraged, Janine immediately rejects the indecent proposal. But, despite the sleaziness of the suggestion, she's flattered someone would be prepared to consider giving up that sort of money just for... her, and the thought of allowing a complete stranger to use her body pushes buttons she didn't know she had.

And why does Adam seem so keen she should do it...?

[Rolled](#) is available from Amazon



X Flies

Over Andy's shoulder I saw Chrissie had removed her dress and was kneeling on the floor between Mark's legs in her black bra, thong and suspender belt. Her stockings and shoes were still on, and her body was excellent. I couldn't help watching as her head moved up and down in Mark's lap.

Amy was now naked and sitting astride James. Her figure was full, but there was no fat on her at all. I had a very clear view of James's hard-on as she heaved herself up and down on it. This was the first time I'd seen a sex act as a bystander, and it was a weird feeling. The thought of watching other people having sex had never appealed before, but was definitely working for me now.

Andy must have seen me watching the other people. "Would you prefer we went to find somewhere a bit more private?" He looked a bit concerned.

"No, here's fine. But thanks." I was enjoying being in the same room as other copulating couples. It felt suitably naughty.



A collection of four hot stories about the illicit thrill derived from having sex with a stranger.

End of the Line - Kerry's husband wants sexy texts to read during a long train journey, and she obliges—revealing fantasies they'd never discussed face to face. But when he tells her he's lost his phone, she goes a lot further than sending just texts.

Hors d'Oeuvres - English art student, Denny, finds himself sitting opposite a strange couple on a late night train out of Paris. The guy is huge, drunk and sleepy. The girl is tiny, sexy and very forward.

Character Reference - *On the night before her interview Angela takes a mild tranquiliser to calm her nerves, but the only thing relaxed is her inhibitions. Having had very little sleep, she needs to think fast next morning to answer all the awkward questions thrown at her.*

Trade - *Denise's husband assures her his obsession with wife-swapping doesn't mean he wants a different life-partner—and she discovers a short-term trade can be a lot of fun.*

[X Flies](#) is available at Amazon.



A Hotwife's Journey

Her key in the door made his heart race. He listened as she came up the stairs, then held his breath when she walked into the bedroom. He couldn't help staring. Her clothes were twisted, her makeup was smudged, and her hair was dishevelled.

She's fucked someone.

Karen walked to the foot of the bed and looked into his face. "I did it."

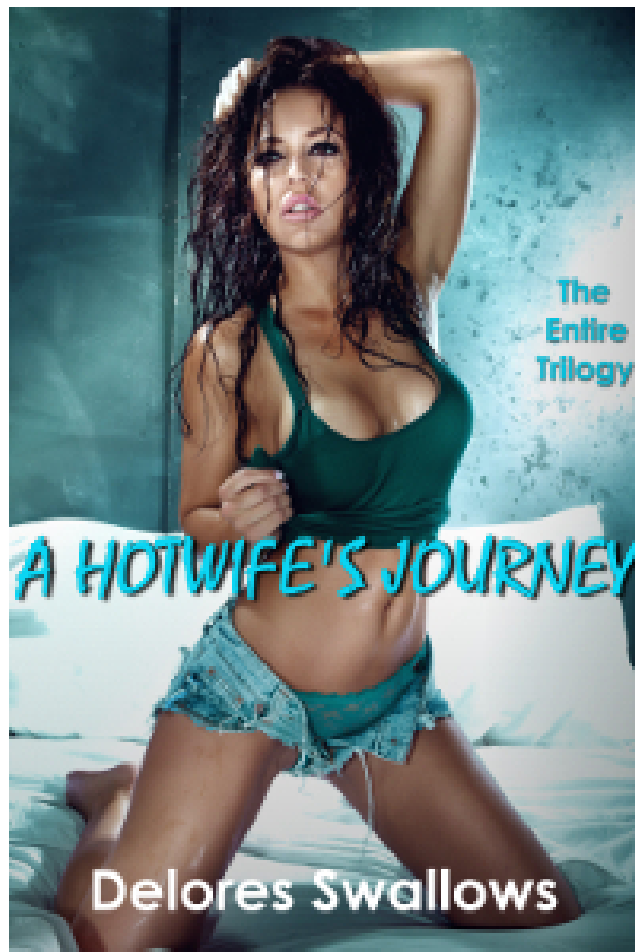
He swallowed.

She pulled her top over her head and dropped it on the floor, then pushed her skirt down over her hips and kicked it away. Slowly, she unclipped her bra at the front. As the cups came away, he saw a love bite on one of her breasts. Karen held his gaze as she pushed her thong down her legs and then bent to pick it up, holding it open so he could see the gooey mess soaked into the crotch.

It was another man's cum, and it'd dribbled out of her during the drive home. The guy had deposited it deep in her cunt, and she'd returned

home to her pervert husband to show him the evidence.

Nigel ached for her.



A Hotwife's Journey

After her husband's open invitation to become a hotwife, Karen enjoys a variety of surprises and adventures that are hotter than any wife could wish for.

This collection covers her entire journey...

Karen's Open Invitation

Nigel is a lucky man. He has everything a man could want: a successful and beautiful wife, a happy marriage, two wonderful daughters, a nice home and his own business.

So why risk it all just to satisfy his dirty fantasy?

When Karen's throwaway comment about a hot colleague in the Sweden office unlocks the door to his secret desires, he offers her the chance to have a little fun; to mix business with pleasure.

Nigel has fantasised about sharing his wife for a long time. And from the way Karen's been behaving lately, he suspects the idea appeals to her, too.

But there's a big difference between fantasy and reality.

Will she take up his suggestion and have a passionate tryst with a virtual stranger while attending an overseas meeting? Neither know the answer when she leaves for the airport, but she doesn't have to make her decision straight away. She can see how the meeting pans out. After all, it's an open invitation...

Karen's Party Surprise

Nigel is amazed by how Karen's taken to her new role as a hotwife. Not only does she give herself freely to strangers, but she also thrills her husband by giving him all the juicy details he craves when she gets home.

Their sex-life is better than ever.

Nigel realises that an upcoming company get together will mean that they'll be staying in the same hotel as Sean, the first man he ever shared her with. He offers Karen the chance to enjoy another night of passion, and they hatch a plan that could work. But Sean comes up with a counteroffer that's just too good to refuse.

For a wife-sharing couple like Nigel and Karen, it's the ultimate party surprise...

Karen's Holiday Adventures

Life keeps getting better and better for Nigel. His long-held wife-sharing fantasy is now his reality, and he couldn't be happier.

Or at least that's what he thinks until his wife reveals her plans for a break.

Their daughters are going away with their cousin's family, so Karen books a holiday for the two of them—on a Caribbean island. What's more, she promises to make it a fun-filled week where nothing is off-limits.

Under the hot tropical sun of St Lucia, Nigel learns just how hot his hotwife can be.

He's shocked by the diversity of her sexual appetite, but then she did promise him an 'anything goes' holiday adventure...

[A Hotwife's Journey](#) is available from Amazon

